



President's economic endpoint is unclear

Amid mixed messaging, investors are questioning shape of Trump's vision

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

President Donald Trump acknowledges that his economic plan is causing short-term pain while the nation advances to a new "Golden Age." But administration officials have been much less clear about what that destination will look like — and how long it will take to get there.

The president talks about reindustrializing the Midwest while his treasury secretary emphasizes weaning Americans from an unhealthy reliance on government spending. Trump's commerce secretary is keen to balance the federal budget. His top White House economic adviser touts the virtues of tax cuts and "massive deregulation."

Amid signs of investor unease, the Trump administration insists it aims to help Main Street, not Wall Street. But so far, the administration's discordant chorus is not satisfying either one. The erratic pace and tone of Trump 2.0 is taking a toll on the stable economy the president inherited, denting growth prospects and leaving Americans more downbeat than they have been in years.

On Friday, a closely watched consumer confidence index sank to its lowest level since November 2022, when inflation was near a 40-year high. The stock market, meanwhile, is losing altitude, as investors fear that the president means what he says about using tariffs to reverse decades of globalization.

"It is a bit of a muddle right now, what they mean. Each of the

SEE **ECONOMY** ON A14

How the Altadena fire outran the alert system

This story is by Joyce Sohyun Lee, Joshua Partlow, John Muyskens, Samuel Oakford, Sarah Kaplan, Brianna Sacks, Aaron C. Davis and Imogen Piper.

ALTADENA, CALIF. — The power had gone out at Erliene Kelley's house, and the wind was howling overhead. But as the 83-year-old peered at her son in the pale glow of her flashlight, she insisted that she was not afraid of the Eaton Fire.

She had no reason to be, Erliene said. The brush fire that broke out four hours earlier had started more than two miles away. Authorities hadn't yet issued an evacuation warning for her neighborhood. And in the nearly six decades she'd lived on Tonia Avenue, no wildfire had ever posed a threat.

It was almost 11 p.m. on Jan. 7, and her son Trevor was exhausted. As he prepared to leave her home, he urged her to come to his. Trevor still had power. He also lived closer to where the fire had started, east of Altadena.

"Why would I go over there?" Erliene said. "I'm safe here."

By the next morning, the blocks around Erliene's blue ranch house would become the tragic center of the fires that burned across Los Angeles County in January. Of the

SEE **ALTADENA** ON A6

Trump envisions a new direction for the Kennedy Center Honors



JIM WATSON/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

President Donald Trump presides over a meeting of the Kennedy Center's refashioned board of trustees. Trump visited the performing arts venue for the first time since his stunning takeover, making suggestions for the annual Honors class, such as Elvis Presley, and seeming to say he would agree to host the ceremony. **Story, A9**

A battle over the power of the autopen

BY MATT VISER

President Donald Trump, who has railed against Canada for its trade policies, blamed Ukraine for being invaded by Russians and criticized judges for ruling against him, has found a new enemy on which to focus his ire: the autopen.

Previous presidents have used the relatively mundane technology to affix a presidential John Hancock on documents when there are too many to sign or it's logistically difficult to do so. It's something akin to a real estate deal via DocuSign, but occasionally with much bigger consequences.

The autopen is a machine that uses real ink to duplicate a human

Trump argues pardons not physically signed by Biden are 'null and void'

signature. It is commonly used for greeting cards, certificates and printed sales pitches.

Trump recently claimed that Joe Biden routinely used the device and suggested without evidence that his unelected aides sometimes did it without his knowledge, illegally usurping the executive powers of the presidency.

"It looked like we had an autopen for a president and we

would've been better off if we had, probably," Trump told reporters around midnight Sunday as he flew back from Florida. "Did he know what he was doing? Did he authorize it? Or is this somebody in an office, maybe a radical left lunatic, just signing whatever that person wants?"

Trump also said the documents Biden did not physically sign were "null and void" — potentially setting up a legal battle even though a number of reviews have concluded that the autopen signings are just as legitimate as ones where a handheld pen is applied to paper.

"That'll be up to a court, but I would say that they're null and void," Trump said. "Because I'm sure Biden didn't have any idea

that it was taking place. And somebody was using an autopen to sign off and to give pardons to, as an example, just one example, but the J-6 unselect committee. Think of it, they gave pardons with an autopen. I don't think Biden knew anything about it."

By Monday morning, Trump said he would not honor the pardons Biden made just before leaving office — in particular those of members and staff of the Joint Select Committee that investigated Trump's role in the Jan. 6 insurrection, including former Republican representatives Liz Cheney of Wyoming and Adam Kinzinger of Illinois and Rep. Jamie Raskin (D-Maryland).

SEE **TRUMP** ON A4

Where ruin blew through, rebuild has barely begun

In N.C., extent of damage and aid is still uncertain after Helene. State lawmakers want faster action.



KATHY KMONICEK/AP

Addisun Cole, 8, plays with Little Bit, her grandmother's cat, on Feb. 5 in Swannanoa, North Carolina. They are living in a trailer after her grandmother's home was destroyed by the remnants of Helene.

BY BRADY DENNIS

The state representative was not pleased.

"North Carolina cannot afford another failed disaster recovery program," Rep. Brenden Jones (R) said inside a Raleigh hearing room on a recent morning, referring to the state's troubled and ongoing rebuilding effort from Hurricanes Matthew and Florence, the latter of which struck in 2018.

Now, nearly six months had passed since the remnants of Hurricane Helene ravaged western North Carolina, and the first home had yet to officially be rebuilt. Jones insisted he and other lawmakers wanted to see shovels in the ground and construction crews at work — and soon.

"We want to see some people being made whole," he told two officials from Gov. Josh Stein's newly created Recovery Office for Western North Carolina.

The recent hearing encapsulated the tensions surfacing after

SEE **HELENE** ON A8

Court conflict nears a boil

WHITE HOUSE SEEKS JUDGE'S REMOVAL

Hearing on deportation flights turns contentious

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL, NATALIE ALLISON, ANN E. MARIMOW AND MARIANNE LEVINE

The Trump administration's battle with the federal court system escalated sharply on Monday, with government lawyers calling for the removal of a judge who blocked the deportation of alleged Venezuelan gang members and refusing to answer some questions in court.

The administration for weeks has questioned the authority of courts to constrain the president, harshly attacking judges who issue nationwide injunctions and finding ways to circumvent certain adverse rulings.

Some legal experts describe the pushback as a breakdown in the fragile balance of powers between the branches of government, which includes lower courts making initial rulings about executive initiatives that can be appealed all the way to the Supreme Court.

Other experts offered more modulated assessments of the Trump administration's aggressive legal posture, while acknowledging the judicial system was being put under intense strain.

Steve Vladeck, a Georgetown University law professor, said the country is seeing "an unprecedented degree of resistance,

SEE **COURTS** ON A4

Trump, Putin set to discuss a ceasefire in phone call

BY MARY ILYUSHINA AND DAN LAMOTHE

President Donald Trump and Russian leader Vladimir Putin are set to speak in a phone call Tuesday to discuss ending the war in Ukraine, the Kremlin confirmed Monday, as the United States seeks Moscow's support for a 30-day ceasefire proposal.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Monday that the call will be mainly about settling the conflict in Ukraine but is also "an important step that sets the tone for the movement to revive relations between the states." Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine began in 2022.

Trump announced the planned call Sunday, saying there was "a very good chance" of reaching a deal. "We are doing pretty well, I think, with Russia," he told reporters aboard Air Force One. "We'll see if we have something to announce, maybe by Tuesday."

When asked what concessions Russia would make in a potential deal, Trump said discussions have taken place about "dividing up" assets. "We will be talking about land. We will be talking about power plants," he said. "I think a lot of it has already been discussed at length by both sides, Ukraine and Russia."

Last week, U.S. officials said

SEE **RUSSIA** ON A11

IN THE NEWS

DEI purge The Pentagon removed a webpage about an Iwo Jima flag-raiser and others celebrating minority service members. **A18**

Living history Dozens of students dressed as historical figures in music, civil rights and other areas, sharing their stories at D.C.'s Blacks in Wax exhibition. **B1**

THE NATION **Amid a measles surge,** doctors and politicians mull who might be the next CDC leader. **A2**
Students at U.S. military bases around the world are resisting a crackdown on DEI. **A5**

THE WORLD **Syria and Lebanon** agreed to halt violence following clashes along their border. **A10**
China is banking on a 30-point plan to revitalize its struggling economy. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **Grass-fed beef** isn't better for the planet than conventional cattle, a new study found. **A13**
The Social Security Administration is considering a change that would force millions of customers to file claims in person rather than by phone. **A14**

THE REGION **Maryland is poised** to become the first state to allocate ACA money to provide reproductive health care. **B1**
Wesley Lowery, a former Post journalist, resigned from American University after allegations of sexual comments. **B1**

STYLE **We've become** less social since the pandemic, but recent trends have managed to keep parties alive. **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE **After a mastectomy,** a writer found that selecting a prosthetic breast was more difficult than she imagined. **E1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A12
COMICS.....C7
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C6
WORLD NEWS.....A10

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